

Billionaires, you need a change of tack

Even as we wait for the **advent** of the world's first dollar trillionaire, the world is **awash with** billionaires - last count being 3,028 of them, according to the 2025 Forbes World's Billionaires List, with a combined wealth of \$16.1 tn. The US leads this **Sinatra-ian rat pack** with 902, followed by China with 450, and our very own '**sovereign** socialist secular democratic republic' with 205. Not to get too **nit-Piketty** about it, this **plethora** of billionaires in an ocean of non-millionaires **has led to bad press**. Which is understandable, if you think about human psychology. It has been so at least since the time of 18th-c. wine merchant-philosopher Jean-Jacques Rousseau, who **quite** logically **stated**, 'When the people shall have nothing more to eat, they will eat the rich.'

The 'people' have not yet **come to such a pass** but, undoubtedly, **conspicuous** consumption of **megacapitalists** has led to a **backlash** in the age of social/antisocial media. Even if the wealthy are not on the menu of the '99%', **demands** for **downsizing** billionaires **are** growing in loudness, with **the likes of** NYC mayoral candidate Zohran Mamdani even wishing for 'no billionaires'. Instead of getting into **economics**, and **pros and cons** of existence of billionaires, the **narrative** can change in the public imagination from being **meme fodder** back to industrial **titans**.



The problem is not wealth, but **optics**. Where once wealth **signified aspiration**, it now **signals alienation**. **Billionaires** tweeting about 'hard work' while their companies **pay peanuts** **have** less **credibility** than a **broccoli endorsement** from **Big Mac**. **Philanthropy** now **raises eyebrows**. Is that donation **altruism**, or tax **jujitsu**? Did they fund climate research, or just **offset** their third rocket launch? Billionaires should **pivot** from tech-bro **enlightenment** to something **resembling earthly humility**. In an age where influence is measured not just in net worth but in net **likeability**, the super-rich must **adapt** their storytelling. Or risk being **cast** as cartoonish **oligarchs** in the public's **grim fairy tale**. Even **Gatsby** had better parties.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Tack** (noun) – approach, strategy, method, policy, course – दृष्टिकोण
2. **Advent** (noun) – arrival, emergence, onset, initiation, beginning – आगमन
3. **Awash** (adjective) – flooded, overflowing, inundated, filled, saturated – भरा हुआ
4. **Sinatra-ian** (adjective) – stylish, flamboyant, charismatic, classic, retro – (फ्रैंक सिनात्रा की शैली से प्रेरित)
5. **Rat pack** (noun) – elite group, clique, gang, circle, crew – चुनिंदा समूह
6. **Sovereign** (adjective) – autonomous, independent, self-governing, supreme, unrestricted – सम्प्रभु
7. **Nit-Piketty** (noun) – critical economist, inequality analyst, wealth critic, fiscal reformer, policy thinker – पिकेटी जैसी आलोचना
8. **Plethora** (noun) – abundance, excess, surplus, profusion, overflow – अत्यधिक मात्रा
9. **Lead to** (verb) – result in, cause, bring about, provoke, generate – कारण बनना
10. **Bad press** (noun) – negative coverage, criticism, censure, disapproval, condemnation – नकारात्मक प्रचार
11. **Quite** (adverb) – entirely, completely, absolutely, totally, thoroughly – पूरी तरह से
12. **State** (verb) – declare, express, assert, mention, claim – कहना
13. **Come to pass** (phrase) – happen, occur, take place, transpire, unfold – घटित होना
14. **Conspicuous** (adjective) – noticeable, prominent, eye-catching, obvious, evident – दिखने योग्य
15. **Megacapitalist** (noun) – ultra-rich, billionaire, tycoon, magnate, plutocrat – महा पूंजीपति
16. **Backlash** (noun) – reaction, repercussion, resistance, retaliation, revolt – प्रतिकूल प्रतिक्रिया
17. **Downsize** (verb) – reduce, cut, shrink, scale down, diminish – घटाना
18. **The likes of** (phrase) – such as, for example, similar to, among others, including – जैसे लोग
19. **Economics** (noun) – finance, commerce, economy, business, fiscal studies – अर्थशास्त्र
20. **Pros and cons** (phrase) – advantages and disadvantages, merits and demerits, positives and negatives, benefits and

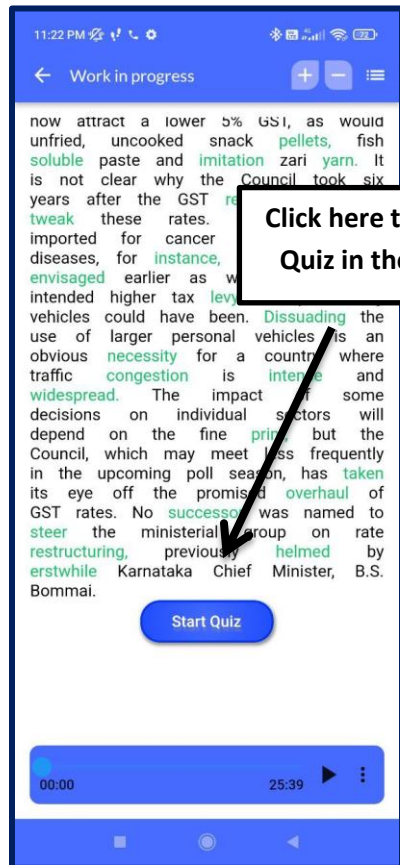
- drawbacks, strengths and weaknesses –
फायदे और नुकसान
21. **Narrative** (noun) – story, account, depiction, portrayal, version – कथा
22. **Meme fodder** (noun) – joke material, satirical content, internet humor, viral topic, parody source – मीम का विषय
23. **Titan** (noun) – giant, colossus, mogul, powerhouse, leader – महाशक्ति
24. **Optics** (noun) – perception, impression, image, appearance, visibility – छवि
25. **Signified** (adjective) – indicated, denoted, represented, conveyed, symbolized – दर्शाया गया
26. **Aspiration** (noun) – ambition, desire, goal, dream, aim – आकांक्षा
27. **Signal** (verb) – indicate, convey, express, show, manifest – संकेत देना
28. **Alienation** (noun) – isolation, estrangement, detachment, exclusion, disconnection – अलगाव
29. **Pay peanuts** (noun) – underpay, low wages, meagre salary, insufficient pay, poor compensation – बहुत कम वेतन देना
30. **Credibility** (noun) – trustworthiness, reliability, believability, integrity, authenticity – विश्वसनीयता
31. **Broccoli endorsement** (noun) – unconvincing praise, fake approval, forced support, sarcastic promotion, reluctant backing – अप्रासंगिक समर्थन
32. **Big Mac** (noun) – fast food symbol, consumerism icon, unhealthy indulgence, mass-market product, brand stereotype – बिग मैक (मैकडॉनल्ड्स का प्रमुख बर्गर)
33. **Philanthropy** (noun) – charity, generosity, benevolence, altruism, donation – परोपकार
34. **Raise eyebrows** (phrase) – cause surprise, provoke disbelief, shock, stir suspicion, spark doubt – हैरानी/संदेह पैदा करना
35. **Altruism** (noun) – selflessness, compassion, generosity, kindness, humanitarianism – परमार्थ
36. **Jujitsu** (noun) – manipulation, strategy, clever move, trick, technique – चालाकी से काम लेना
37. **Offset** (verb) – counterbalance, neutralize, compensate, balance, equalize – संतुलित करना
38. **Pivot** (verb) – shift, change, alter, adapt, transition – दिशा बदलना
39. **Enlightenment** (noun) – awareness, insight, wisdom, knowledge, awakening – प्रबोधन

40. **Resemble** (verb) – look like, appear like, mirror, imitate, simulate – जैसा दिखना
41. **Earthly** (adjective) – humble, human, grounded, real, modest – सांसारिक
42. **Humility** (noun) – modesty, meekness, humbleness, submission, simplicity – विनम्रता
43. **Likeability** (noun) – charm, appeal, attractiveness, affability, approachability – पसंद किया जाना
44. **Adapt** (verb) – adjust, modify, change, alter, accommodate – अनुकूल बनना
45. **Cast** (verb) – portray, depict, show, represent, frame – चित्रित करना
46. **Oligarch** (noun) – plutocrat, magnate, tycoon, elite, autocrat – अभिजात शासक
47. **Grim** (adjective) – bleak, harsh, gloomy, serious, severe – गंभीर
48. **Tale** (noun) – story, narrative, fable, yarn, chronicle – कहानी
49. **Gatsby** (noun) – extravagant host, symbol of wealth, mysterious millionaire, fictional magnate, party icon – गैट्सबी (अमीर और प्रसिद्ध चरित्र, F. Scott Fitzgerald की रचना)

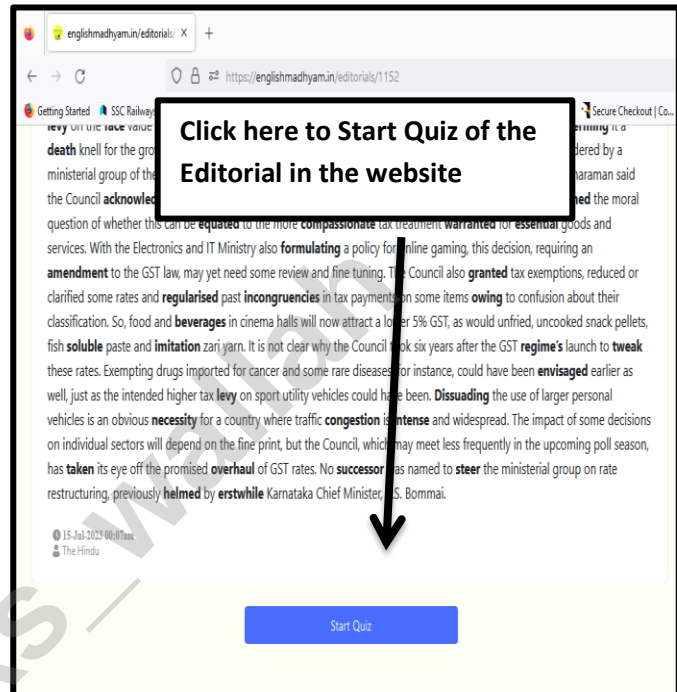
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Global Billionaire Surge:** The world currently has 3,028 billionaires with a combined wealth of \$16.1 trillion, led by the U.S., China, and India.
2. **Imminent Trillionaire Era:** The world is nearing the emergence of its first dollar trillionaire.
3. **Wealth Inequality Highlighted:** This extreme concentration of wealth exists amid a global population where most are not even millionaires.
4. **Public Backlash Rising:** The public, influenced by economic disparity and social media, is increasingly critical of the super-rich.
5. **Historical Parallels:** The resentment echoes the warning by philosopher Rousseau—extreme inequality can lead to social revolt.
6. **Social Media Amplifies Criticism:** Platforms have made it easier for public anger and criticism of billionaires' lavish lifestyles to go viral.
7. **Anti-Billionaire Sentiment:** Political voices like Zohran Mamdani openly advocate for a world without billionaires.
8. **Wealth Optics Matter More Now:** Wealth is no longer admired as a sign of success; it's often seen as evidence of exploitation or disconnection.
9. **Credibility Crisis:** Billionaires' public statements on merit and hard work seem hollow when their workers are underpaid.
10. **Skepticism Toward Philanthropy:** Donations by the ultra-wealthy are viewed with suspicion—as either image-cleaning or tax avoidance.
11. **Space vs Earth Concern:** Funding rocket launches while global problems persist paints billionaires as out of touch.
12. **Need for Humility:** The editorial calls for a shift from “tech-bro” arrogance to grounded, relatable humility.
13. **Influence Has New Metrics:** In today's world, net likeability may matter more than net worth for sustained public influence.
14. **Reputation Management:** Billionaires must tell better, more humane stories to regain public trust.
15. **Warning of Social Alienation:** If they don't change their narrative and behavior, billionaires risk being seen as villains in society's unfolding drama.

Practice Exercise: Banking Pattern Based



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